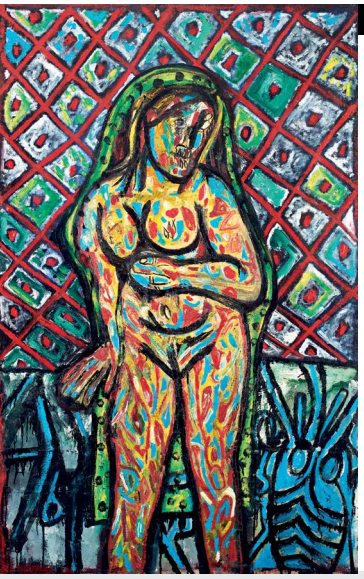


creative people who were similarly shunned because authority figures feared that they would 'upset the apple cart'. Not surprisingly, Souza was a founder member of the Progressive Artists' Group (PAG) along with M.F. Husain, K.A. Ara, H.A. Gade, S.H. Raza, and S.K. Bakre. They were symbolic of a different wave in Indian art, more avant-garde, and in tune with global ideologies.

The modernist had to move to London's more open-minded art scene in 1949 before his theme found acceptance, and his oeuvre internationally lauded. Minal Vazirani, co-founder and president of Saffronart, says of his work, "Souza could often be unnervingly confrontational and brutal in his exploration of human nature—as you can observe in many of his iconic 'Heads'—but there was also a paradoxically vulnerable side to him seen in his depictions of mother and child and some of his more tender nudes."

Of the 48 lots that will be part of this auction, in many different mediums and styles, the most talked about is 'Untitled (Pieta)', 1987, which is estimated to go for Rs 3-5 crore. The acrylic-on-canvas painting captures the tenderness of the Virgin Mary cradling the body of Christ after his crucifixion. It's said to be especially significant because of the artist's close relationship with his mother Lilia Maria Antunes, whose passing in the same year that it was painted imbues the work with a deeply personal sense of loss.

Be it 'Californian Girl' or the untitled ones of a veiled nude and a family, many of Souza's works have a subtle subversive message, calling out things such as racism and the hypocrisy of religion. This is what keeps his art relevant and in-demand even today. While buying an F.N. Souza work might be every collector's dream, viewing all of these together gives art lovers a sense of his bold brilliance and the way his artistic style evolved down the decades. ■

–Priya Pathiyan



BOLD & BRILLIANT (Clockwise from left) 'Untitled (Head with Horns)', 1966; 'Untitled (Pieta)', 1987; 'Untitled (Veiled Nude)', 1964

Of the 48 lots that will be part of this auction, in many different mediums and styles, the most talked about is 'Untitled (Pieta)', 1987, estimated to go for Rs 3-5 crore

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decade-long journey as an artist of mixed ancestry, who has meditated on the meanings of traversing through times and spaces—both in a personal capacity, and as a larger cultural commentary. "The different architectural styles added throughout the years represent the changing landscape, like unique time-stamps of each decade," she notes.

The plurality of Mukerjee Logue's identity is visible in the fluidity of her brushstrokes that animate the roads and the structures that have raised her. She plays with light and illumination in ways that allow the shadows of her women to dance against the earthy palette of her landscapes, reminiscent of the works of Gaganendranath Tagore. It is, therefore, no surprise that he has been one of her inspirations. "Some of Tagore's paintings have been favourites of mine, like 'Pratima Visarjan' for the glow and light captured and 'Meeting at the Staircase' for the intimate moment and simplicity."

It's evident that women are key to Mukerjee Logue's world, especially in this show that marks a form of homecoming for her. There's a tangible softness, calm and depth to her art that gently spotlights the women as the social glue, holding their different worlds together. In one, a woman is seen bringing food to her child; in another, a motley crew of them are engrossed in spirited conversations; in yet another, three of them might be exchanging pleasantries while crossing paths. Mukerjee Logue paints her everydays with her women. She plants them in public spheres where women have conventionally been invisibilised.

"I often highlight the importance of being a woman, a mother and a storyteller," says Mukerjee Logue. After all, in several cultures, a woman, a mother and a storyteller are indeed synonymous in their connotations of being the custodians of cultural knowledge and histories, much like they are on Mukerjee Logue's canvas. ■

–Arshia